

Telecom, Cable & Satellite

Addressing Key Questions and Debates Ahead of 2Q26 Earnings

Ahead of the 2Q26 earnings season, we address key industry questions/debates across the mobile phone, broadband, and video ecosystems. Our favorite names going into earnings remain Overweight-rated T-Mobile, Viasat, and Quebecor, while Underweight-rated TELUS remains our top short idea.

Question #1 – How could Starlink enter the U.S. wireless market?

With SpaceX signaling its interest in entering the U.S. wireless market, the key debate is the path of entry. We see three broad options: a standalone terrestrial build, which remains our base case; a U.S. MVNO, which we view as unlikely near term and a coin flip long term; or the acquisition of a U.S. carrier, which we view as unlikely but potentially more favorable for industry structure than the emergence of a new fourth player. Under our base case, SpaceX would build its own network, including an estimated 75k sites, and acquire additional spectrum. Even with the pending acquisition of 65 MHz from EchoStar, Starlink Mobile would likely need to augment its holdings further, and we model an additional \$30.0b of spectrum globally through 2031. SpaceX would also need low-band spectrum to support in-building penetration, but available low-band is limited. All in, we model mobile-related capex of \$111b through 2031, or 56% of Connectivity segment capex, underscoring the capital intensity and execution complexity of a broader U.S. rollout. On the MVNO path, the Big-3 appear to see little benefit in granting Starlink access today, a view reinforced by their recently announced direct-to-device joint venture. We therefore view a near-term U.S. MVNO as unlikely and a long-term arrangement as a coin flip. Finally, SpaceX could acquire a U.S. carrier, though we view this as unlikely given the substantial regulatory pushback it would likely face. Still, from an industry-structure perspective, we would view an acquisition as a more favorable outcome than the emergence of a well-capitalized fourth player.

Question #2 – How much of a threat is Starlink Mobile to U.S. wireless?

Viewing a near-term U.S. MVNO as unlikely, we see Starlink Mobile as more of a lingering overhang on U.S. wireless than a near-term fundamental threat, with limited expected pressure on the roughly \$240b U.S. mobile service revenue ecosystem over our forecast horizon. We model SpaceX beginning its U.S. terrestrial build in 2028 and launching a U.S. direct-to-consumer service in 2029. Our U.S. DTC forecast ramps to 2m subscribers in 2029, 4m in 2030, and 5m by year-end 2031; in 2030, that represents just ~1% of total U.S. phone subscribers and \$1.4b of service revenue, or only ~0.5% of industry service revenue. Structurally, direct-to-device connectivity cannot replicate the in-building penetration or capacity of terrestrial networks, handset compatibility remains limited, and Starlink Mobile's value proposition versus incumbents remains unclear. We expect pricing on par with cable MVNOs rather than at a steep discount; those offers launched in 2017 and scaled to more than 21m subscribers with only minimal impact on incumbents' profit pools. With U.S. "dysconnectivity" not severe enough to drive large-scale demand for a satellite-supplemented service, we view Starlink Mobile as a supplement to existing coverage rather than a competitive substitute. Net-net, the bigger near-term impact

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is likely sentiment rather than fundamentals: even if Starlink Mobile's direct subscriber and revenue share remains modest, the prospect of a future terrestrial build, eventual MVNO, or broader SpaceX ecosystem strategy should keep disruption risk in the investor debate until the company's ultimate ambitions become clearer.

Question #3 – Can Starlink take meaningful share from cable in U.S. broadband?

We expect Starlink Broadband to take meaningful share from cable in the U.S. residential broadband market as lower-cost capacity, cheaper user terminals, and pricing flexibility expand its addressable market beyond its core rural geographies. From an estimated 2.52m U.S. subscribers exiting 2025, we forecast Starlink Broadband scaling to 12.19m by year-end 2030, including net adds of 1.34m in 2026 and 2.03m in 2027. The acceleration is driven by Starship-enabled V3 Broadband satellite launches, which we estimate will deliver roughly 24x the downlink capacity per launch relative to Falcon 9. Smaller, lighter, and cheaper user terminals should further support adoption, while lower capacity costs should give Starlink room to price more aggressively as it competes more directly with cable. Consistent with that strategy, we model developed-market broadband ARPU declining at a 14% CAGR from 2025 through 2030, reflecting a deliberate shift toward volume as unit economics improve. We believe these levers position Starlink to penetrate the estimated 20% of U.S. homes, or roughly 30m, that we expect will not be passed by fiber over the long term, a predominantly cable-dominant segment, with our 2030 forecast implying 39% penetration of that cohort. On balance, we see satellite's share of total U.S. residential broadband subscribers rising to 8% by year-end 2030 from 3% in 2025, with cable ceding the majority of Starlink's net adds and fixed wireless access (FWA) also losing some share. We expect cable's share to fall to 44% from 57% over the same period. To reflect this anticipated capacity ramp and competitive pressure, we recently raised our total cable residential broadband net loss estimate to 2.06m for 2027, including declines of 550k for both Comcast and Charter, with net losses worsening over the forecast period.

Question #4 – With demand for spectrum assets growing among direct-to-device players, who are the potential sellers?

We believe MSS spectrum demand will remain robust as direct-to-device (D2D) operators including SpaceX/Starlink, Amazon LEO, and AST SpaceMobile seek additional capacity and geographic coverage. Recent transactions support this view, including Amazon's acquisition of Globalstar, SpaceX's purchase of 65 MHz from EchoStar, and AST SpaceMobile's licensing of spectrum from Ligado, while Rocket Lab's acquisition of Iridium broadens the buyer universe beyond pure-play D2D and points to a longer-term market of vertically integrated launch-and-connectivity players. Against this backdrop, we see Viasat, Anterix, and SiriusXM as the key spectrum monetization beneficiaries. We are most constructive on Viasat, whose global L-Band and S-Band spectrum portfolio we value at \$16.1b (\$0.28/MHz-pop). Following the European Commission's decision to reshape how 2 GHz satellite spectrum is allocated across the EU, Viasat is well positioned to monetize a portion of its European holdings to SpaceX and/or AST SpaceMobile, particularly as SpaceX looks to bring more D2D traffic on-net in geographies such as Europe and Australia. We are similarly bullish on Anterix, which still trades at roughly \$0.56/MHz-pop versus our \$0.75/MHz-pop value; its 900 MHz multi-use spectrum covers 85% of U.S. counties, including many major metros, and its 11 contracts to date have priced at an average of ~\$1.40/MHz-pop. Domestically, SiriusXM appears more likely to pursue partnership-led value creation than an outright sale of its 2 GHz spectrum; at J.P. Morgan's TMC Conference in May, CFO Zac Coughlin said he does not "envision a single monetization event but rather a phased approach, with timelines gated by technology development and partnership availability." One development we'll be watching is the FCC's July 16 proposal to open 200+ MHz of unlicensed spectrum for D2D, up for consideration August 6; we view it as complementary,

not substitutive, as carrier-grade D2D still needs exclusive, interference-protected licensed spectrum and the proposal remains early-stage.

Question #5 – How do we expect Comcast's separation into two companies to play out?

We agree with Comcast's plan to [separate](#) into two publicly traded companies but are somewhat surprised by the timing, given management's prior commentary; on the 4Q25 call in January, Co-CEO Mike Cavanagh dismissed speculation about an NBCU spinout, arguing management saw no "strategic advantage" in separating NBCU and that a standalone entity "doesn't get stronger by being smaller." While management framed the spin-off around sharper strategic focus, capital allocation clarity, and greater flexibility in a more competitive landscape, we believe the decision sets the stage for cable and/or media M&A in the coming years. In particular, we see a Comcast/Charter combination as likely over time, a scenario we have [explored](#) previously; while the scale of a combined entity may draw pushback, the current competitive environment could allow a deal to clear, though capital structure remains a key consideration and full run-rate synergies could total \$2-3b across opex and capex. On timing, Charter must first close its acquisition of Cox, on which the [CPUC](#) is expected to vote August 13, then begin integration and further [de-lever](#) before entertaining a Comcast combination. On the NBCU side, we see the spun entity as more likely a seller than a buyer, given potential tech-platform interest in its studio and parks assets; Netflix's terminated Warner Bros. bid cited deep film and TV libraries and beloved franchises, attributes that also describe NBCU and Universal Studios in particular. That said, while NBCU's broadcast networks and stations would trigger extensive FCC review, its sports heft, particularly the NFL and NBA, could prove attractive to streamers.

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